

ServeMaster Academy

First Crossings

Companion Workbook

Exercises, wine pairings, and service scenarios drawn from each of the twelve chapters.

Answers at the back.

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Each chapter has three parts:

%° Knowledge Check

Four multiple-choice questions on wine, service technique, and the chapter setting. One best answer — the others represent common mistakes or partial truths.

%° Scenario Prompt

An open-ended situation drawn from the chapter's key service moment. Write freely, then review against your own experience.

%° Skills Checklist

Five statements about the chapter's core skills. Tick what you own, circle what you're working on. Return after your next shift.

Answers to the Knowledge Check are in the Answer Key at the back, with a brief explanation of why each answer is correct — and what makes the wrong answers wrong.

CHAPTER 1

The City That Starts Without You

Florence, Italy — Gucci Osteria da Massimo Bottura

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia Vale arrives in Florence for her first shift at Gucci Osteria (one Michelin star). Under floor manager Elena, she saves a tray of tortellini mid-service using instinct she didn't know she'd built, oversees a Barolo presentation at an anniversary table, and wins over a six-year-old with a kitchen detour. By the time she cycles home along the Arno, "technique" has become something she owns rather than follows.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Elena presents the 2016 Barolo Castiglione as:

- A) A long recitation of its technical profile
- B) A brief story, offered to the room — not at it
- C) A formal pairing recommendation with the menu
- D) A question about the guests' regional preferences

2. The correct sequence for pouring wine at a restaurant table is:

- A) Left to right regardless of seating
- B) Host first, then clockwise
- C) Clockwise from the right, host last
- D) Ladies first, then gentlemen

3. Sofia's tray save worked because she:

- A) Slowed down and called for help
- B) Passed the tray to a nearby busser
- C) Snapped her elbow to her ribs, threw her hip weight left, and kept moving
- D) Set the tray down on the nearest surface immediately

4. Elena's Barolo was described as pairing beautifully tonight with:

- A) The risotto allo zafferano
- B) The tortellini in brodo
- C) The vitello (veal)
- D) The amuse bouche

SERVICE SCENARIO

A six-year-old at table eight pushes away his amuse bouche with maximum drama. His mother is mortified. Three surrounding tables hold their breath.

Using Sofia's approach as a model, walk through exactly what you do — step by step, from the moment you notice the tension forming. Explain why each move matters.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I can carry a full service tray and correct a tilt without stopping or drawing attention
- ☐ I pour clockwise from the right, saving the host for last
- ☐ I read a table's pace and emotional state before I reach it
- ☐ I describe wine as a brief story offered to the room — not a sales pitch at the guest
- ☐ When a child creates tension in the dining room, I work with the child, not around them

CHAPTER 2

Paris Precision

Paris, France — Plénitude at Hôtel Cheval Blanc (Three Michelin Stars)

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Luca Voss, shaped by his engineer father's precision and his Amalfi mother's instinct for people, is three months into a stage at Plénitude. When the pigeon course is delayed two minutes, he doesn't wait — he bridges the table with a 2015 Clos de Tart, turning the gap into a gift. After service he writes three words: "Precision and warmth. Not opposites."

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. When the kitchen pings a two-minute delay on the main course, Luca's correct move is:

- A) Go to the table immediately and apologise for the wait
- B) Say nothing and allow the natural pause to extend
- C) Offer a bridge wine without framing it as compensation for a delay
- D) Offer a complimentary dessert course at the end

2. The Clos de Tart is from which appellation?

- A) Gevrey-Chambertin
- B) Chambolle-Musigny
- C) Morey-Saint-Denis
- D) Pommard

3. How does Luca present the bottle of 1998 Lafite to Monsieur Laurent?

- A) Upright, with the label facing outward
- B) Horizontally, label angled toward the light so Laurent can confirm
- C) Already opened and resting in a decanter
- D) From a wine cart, label-down in a cradle

4. After completing the pour at table nine, Luca retreats how many paces?

- A) One pace, staying within reach
- B) Two paces, close but not hovering
- C) Five paces, to the far wall
- D) He stays tableside until Laurent nods

SERVICE SCENARIO

The kitchen tells you the main course for your best table is running six minutes late. The host — a sharp-eyed executive — has already glanced at his watch twice.

Walk through exactly what you say, how you frame it, and what you physically do at the table. Why does your approach work better than a simple apology?

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I know how to offer a bridge wine or bite without mentioning the delay
- ☐ I present bottles horizontally with the label toward the guest
- ☐ I can identify which wines on my list work as mid-meal bridges
- ☐ I pour clockwise, host last, with a clean twist at the finish
- ☐ I retreat two paces after pouring and read the table with peripheral attention

CHAPTER 3

The Near Miss

Paris, France — Pont des Arts / Jardin du Luxembourg

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia and Luca are in the same city but never quite connect — she sketches his restaurant's windows from the Pont des Arts while he runs past; they shelter under neighbouring awnings in a Luxembourg rainstorm but don't cross the ten feet between them. Each encounter leaves a trace: a silhouette in a sketchbook, a notebook entry.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. **Sofia's months in service have transformed the habit of reading people into:**
 - A) A conscious checklist she runs at every table
 - B) A professional skill she can switch off outside of work
 - C) An involuntary reflex she applies everywhere — trains, queues, café windows
 - D) A technique she uses only in fine-dining contexts
2. **Luca's mother Rosaria's philosophy of service was:**
 - A) "Systems work cleaner alone"
 - B) "You learn or you don't"
 - C) "Precision before warmth, always"
 - D) "Arrive early; leave last"
3. **Elena "offers the wine to the room, not at the room." What does this mean in practice?**
 - A) Speaking loudly enough for all guests within earshot
 - B) Making the description feel like shared discovery rather than a sales pitch
 - C) Avoiding direct eye contact while presenting the bottle
 - D) Letting the host make all wine decisions without input
4. **In hospitality, sensing what a guest needs before they articulate it is called:**
 - A) Reactive service
 - B) Anticipatory service
 - C) Prescriptive service
 - D) Passive attentiveness

SERVICE SCENARIO

A guest at your station has glanced toward the kitchen three times in two minutes. They haven't said a word. Nothing is technically wrong — water is full, napkin is fine.

What are your options? What do you do first, and why? What does this look like if you get it right versus if you get it wrong?

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I read a table's energy before I reach it — pace, posture, eye movement
- ☐ I describe wine as an invitation, not a presentation
- ☐ I can distinguish when a guest needs attention versus when they need space
- ☐ I stay slightly ahead of the meal's rhythm, not behind it
- ☐ I act on what I observe even before it has been said

CHAPTER 4

Florence Rhythm

Florence, Italy — Gucci Osteria (six months in)

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia has found her footing. At table eleven, an unhappy guest declares his risotto "stone cold." Sofia listens fully, asks one question before doing anything, replaces the dish, and adds four glasses of amaro Nonino as an unannounced gift. He leaves twenty percent. Post-shift drinks with Paolo and Maria. A call with Avó.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. When the guest at table eleven holds his fork over his risotto and declares it cold, Sofia's first move is:

- A) Immediately apologise and take the plate to the kitchen
- B) Explain that risotto is always served at a specific temperature
- C) Ask "When did you notice it cooling?" — then listen fully before responding
- D) Signal the floor manager to handle it

2. Amaro Nonino is best described as:

- A) A sparkling aperitivo from Friuli
- B) A bitter alpine digestif with a grappa base
- C) A light, dry white wine
- D) A sweet dessert wine

3. Sofia returns the replacement dish with four amaro glasses. She delivers this by:

- A) Announcing it as a complimentary gesture for the inconvenience
- B) Setting the glasses down as if this had always been part of the evening's plan
- C) Asking the table's permission before pouring
- D) Handing the amaro only to the complaining guest

4. Brunello di Montalcino is a wine from:

- A) Tuscany
- B) Piedmont
- C) Veneto
- D) Umbria

SERVICE SCENARIO

A guest sends back a pasta course, saying it's overcooked. The kitchen has been under pressure tonight — the printer died at 8 p.m. and they've been calling tickets by memory.

How do you handle the table — what do you say and what is your tone? What do you say to the kitchen afterward, and how do you frame it?

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I receive a complaint without deflecting, over-apologising, or interrupting
- ☐ I listen fully — eye contact, no nod until the guest is finished — before I respond
- ☐ I know what a recovery gesture looks like: small, unannounced, delivered as a gift
- ☐ I never use the word "complimentary" when delivering a comp
- ☐ I follow up with the kitchen constructively — not as blame, but as information

CHAPTER 5

Paris Deepening

Paris, France — Table at 12 rue de Prague (Bruno Verjus)

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Luca trials at Bruno Verjus's Table — twelve covers, ingredient-obsessed. He arrives expecting to deploy his architecture of precision and quickly realises it's the floor, not the ceiling. Camille silently delivers warm bread to a table bracing for a kitchen delay. Verjus's debrief: "Precision is the frame. Empathy fills it."

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Verjus's philosophy at Table is captured in the line:

- A) Speed above all else — covers per hour is what matters
- B) Systems running cleanly produce warmth automatically
- C) "Precision is the frame. Empathy fills it."
- D) "Warmth without structure collapses under pressure"

2. Camille solves the kitchen delay at table five by:

- A) Apologising and offering a small discount on the bill
- B) Asking the couple if they'd prefer to start the cheese course early
- C) Placing warm rye bread silently, as though it had always been planned
- D) Flagging the kitchen and asking them to expedite

3. Verjus evaluates produce — including the radishes — primarily by:

- A) Measuring diameter against a size chart
- B) Tasting and listening for whether it "sings" — a subjective aliveness
- C) Checking colour against a reference card
- D) Calling the farmer and asking about growing conditions

4. When Luca writes "Precision and warmth. Not opposites" he means:

- A) Empathy can replace precision when dealing with upset guests
- B) Technical excellence and human connection reinforce each other
- C) You must choose one depending on the restaurant's style
- D) Warmth is for guests; precision is for the kitchen

SERVICE SCENARIO

You're across the room when you notice a guest's shoulders drop slightly. She's been waiting for her main. Nothing has been said — water is full.

You haven't been called. What do you do, when do you do it, and how do you explain your decision at the debrief?

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I can identify when a guest's body signals a need before they speak it
- ☐ I deliver a bridge — bread, amuse, tisane — without framing it as a delay acknowledgment
- ☐ I understand the difference between observing a problem and solving it
- ☐ I act within my station on instinct, without waiting for direction
- ☐ I can articulate my service decisions in a post-shift debrief

CHAPTER 6

The City That Shouts

Barcelona, Spain — Quimet i Quimet (Est. 1914)

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia stages at Quimet i Quimet — standing room, twenty square meters, turning twenty covers an hour at peak. No tables, no menu. Speed-first, read the eyes not the mouths, carry four glasses in your arms simultaneously. Then evenings at Le Cordon Bleu Barcelona. And at the end, Quim tells her to apply to Disfrutar.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Quimet i Quimet has been family-run since:

- A) 1814
- B) 1914
- C) 1952
- D) 1978

2. When a tourist couple stares at the conservas shelf "delighted but slightly overwhelmed," Sofia:

- A) Hands them a written menu and gives them time
- B) Asks what kind of fish they usually enjoy
- C) Brings razor clams without being asked — and watches their faces shift
- D) Calls Quim over to handle the table

3. "Conservas" at a Spanish bar like Quimet i Quimet refers to:

- A) House-made pickled vegetables
- B) Premium tinned seafood and preserved produce
- C) Spanish cured meats sliced to order
- D) A style of tapas presentation on small ceramic plates

4. On her last shift, Quim's parting advice to Sofia is to apply to:

- A) El Bulli (Ferran Adrià's legendary restaurant)
- B) Tickets (Albert Adrià's Barcelona spot)
- C) Disfrutar (three stars, Oriol Castro's team)
- D) La Boqueria (the central market)

SERVICE SCENARIO

A guest at your tapas bar speaks no Spanish, has never been before, and is frozen in front of the menu. You have a full bar and twelve people queued behind them. You have thirty seconds.

What do you do exactly? What do you say (or not say), what do you bring, and how do you make this feel like the best moment of their afternoon?

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I can assess a customer's familiarity level within the first three seconds
- ☐ I guide a choice confidently and warmly without overwhelming or condescending
- ☐ I carry multiple items simultaneously in tight, standing-room spaces
- ☐ I recover tray balance without stopping, drawing attention, or breaking stride
- ☐ I maintain accuracy during speed — I don't sacrifice one for the other

CHAPTER 7

Millimeter Work

Barcelona, Spain — Disfrutar (Three Michelin Stars)

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia stages at Disfrutar under Javier and Carla, serving Oriol Castro's tasting menu — deconstructed paella, birch sap spheres, a nitro-frozen espuma tower that melts tableside in fifteen seconds. "Silence means awe — don't interrupt awe." In the tenth shift, a shoulder clip nearly sends the espuma down. Sofia catches it. Javier sees everything: "Millimeter save."

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Carla's instruction — "silence means awe, don't interrupt awe" — means:

- A) Keep speaking during placement to fill any silence
- B) After placing a transforming course, step back and let the moment happen at its own pace
- C) Check in every ninety seconds during a dramatic course
- D) Ask the guest if they're enjoying the experience

2. The "liquid forest" progression at Disfrutar consists of:

- A) Three cocktails with foraged botanicals
- B) Birch sap spheres, moss gelée in porcelain hollows, and a nitro-frozen espuma tower
- C) A sequence of forest mushroom dishes
- D) A tableside smoke infusion over three courses

3. The espuma tower's key service challenge is that:

- A) It must be consumed immediately before the guest speaks
- B) Contact with any surface will permanently deflate it
- C) Temperature change begins a fifteen-second timed transformation — the guest watches it happen
- D) It must be kept upright in a magnetic cradle until placement

4. Sofia's espuma save involved:

- A) Calling for help from Carla, who stabilised the tray
- B) Setting the tray down on the nearest surface and composing herself
- C) A two-handed correction — thumb driving the tray edge, free hand's pinky feathering under the espuma base
- D) Slowing her pace and leaning against the service trolley

SERVICE SCENARIO

You're serving a course that transforms visibly at the table — a frozen element melting, a gel dissolving, a sauce poured tableside. You have one sentence of announcement, then you step back.

Write out exactly what you say. Then explain why every word earns its place — and what you deliberately chose not to say.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I can adjust my physical technique from tapas-bar speed to fine-dining millimeter precision
- ☐ I know when silence is the best service I can offer
- ☐ I announce a course transformation clearly, then get out of its way
- ☐ I distinguish the silence of pleasure from the silence of confusion
- ☐ I rehearse physical placement in an empty dining room before service begins

CHAPTER 8

The Widower's Wine

Paris, France — Le Gabriel at La Réserve (Two Michelin Stars)

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Luca is at Le Gabriel — 28 covers, intimate. "The guests here come because they're lonely," Raoul says. Monsieur Henriot, a widower, dines every Thursday at 20:02. Over three weeks Luca pieces together that Henriot's late wife loved Chassagne-Montrachet. One Thursday, without being asked, he brings the bottle. Henriot says "She would have liked this room." Luca retreats and doesn't look back for twelve minutes.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Why does Luca bring Monsieur Henriot the Chassagne-Montrachet?

- A) It's on promotion and fits Henriot's spending habits
- B) He's pieced together from fragments that Henriot's wife loved this wine
- C) It's the most expensive white on the list and Henriot always orders well
- D) Henriot requested it via the reservation notes

2. Chassagne-Montrachet is:

- A) A red Burgundy from the Côte de Nuits
- B) A white Burgundy from the Côte de Beaune
- C) A Champagne-method sparkling wine from the Mâconnais
- D) A Loire Valley Chenin Blanc

3. After presenting the wine and pouring two fingers for Henriot, Luca:

- A) Stays tableside and talks through the wine's complete tasting profile
- B) Retreats two paces and doesn't look back for twelve minutes
- C) Returns after three minutes to check if everything is satisfactory
- D) Waits at arm's length in case Henriot wants to speak

4. Raoul tells Luca: "The guests here come because they're lonely." The practical implication is:

- A) Offer companionship and conversation as part of the service experience
- B) Maintain strict professional distance to avoid overstepping
- C) A guest's emotional state shapes what they actually need tonight — read it and respond
- D) Always ask about personal circumstances during the amuse course

SERVICE SCENARIO

A solo guest has eaten in your section every Thursday for a month. You've noticed patterns: same wine, eats slowly, looks at the room. Tonight they seem heavier — quieter than usual.

How do you serve this person? What might you bring that you haven't been asked for? What do you leave completely alone?

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I keep notes on regular guests' preferences, patterns, and emotional tells
- ☐ I know the difference between a personal touch that lands and one that intrudes
- ☐ I give space after a meaningful gesture — I don't hover to watch it land
- ☐ I understand that some guests come for the room as much as the food
- ☐ I use memory as a form of welcome — quietly, without announcing what I've noticed

CHAPTER 9

London Borough Market

London, UK — Ikoyi at St James's Market / Borough Market

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Luca stages at Ikoyi — two Michelin stars, West African cuisine, a flavour profile he has never studied. He adapts: off-dry Riesling for scotch bonnet heat, chilled sorrel tisane as a palate bridge. At Borough Market, he stands at the oyster stall next to a woman writing pairing notes in her notebook. He reads them — they're excellent — opens his mouth, and his phone goes off. He leaves a single oyster shell on the ledge.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. For West African dishes with layers of scotch bonnet heat, Luca's pairing choice is:

- A) A tannic red Bordeaux to match the dish's intensity
- B) An off-dry Riesling, whose residual sweetness cools the heat
- C) An oaked Chardonnay to complement the richness
- D) Champagne to cleanse the palate between bites

2. The Whitstable rock oyster is described as having:

- A) A creamy, buttery finish with hints of brie
- B) A sharp citrus and black pepper profile
- C) Sea brine, a green melon mid-note, and a chalk mineral finish
- D) A clean, neutral flavour with no particular mineral character

3. For the plantain gnocchi at Ikoyi, Luca pairs:

- A) White Burgundy (Chardonnay)
- B) South African Chenin Blanc
- C) Australian Riesling
- D) Spanish Albariño

4. The sorrel tisane Luca serves at Ikoyi is described as:

- A) A warm tea service between courses
- B) Hibiscus and pineapple leaf, chilled, used as a palate-reset bridge
- C) A cold-brew coffee served after dessert
- D) A house shrub made from Nigerian palm wine

SERVICE SCENARIO

You're working a restaurant whose cuisine is outside your training. A guest asks what wine to pair with the chef's signature dish.

How do you navigate this honestly without losing the guest's confidence? What does intellectual honesty look like in a service context — and how is it different from admitting you don't know?

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I know that off-dry whites (Riesling, Chenin Blanc) cool heat rather than amplify it
- ☐ I taste every dish on the menu before I recommend a pairing for it
- ☐ I can explain a pairing in plain, sensory language — not technical jargon
- ☐ I adapt my wine knowledge to unfamiliar cuisines using flavour logic, not geography
- ☐ When I'm learning, I frame it as curiosity — not as a gap I'm hiding

CHAPTER 10

Barcelona Farewell

Barcelona, Spain — Le Cordon Bleu Barcelona / Quimet i Quimet final shift

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Sofia passes her Le Cordon Bleu sommelier exam with 98% — a Distinction. Three seconds of stillness, then a Rioja described while pouring it (black cherry, vanilla oak, tannins that cut fat) in the language of truth, not performance. The farewell at Quimet i Quimet: the whole crew, conservas jars glowing under bare bulbs, Quim calling her "mi americana con alma española." She packs her sketchbook and flies to London.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Sofia describes the Rioja as pairing well with jamón because:

- A) They come from the same region and share terroir characteristics
- B) The wine's tannins cut the fat of the cured meat — a structural pairing
- C) It's the lightest red on the list and won't overwhelm the flavour
- D) The producer specifically recommends it in their tasting notes

2. At the exam station, the correct timing for a service description is:

- A) Speak first, then pour — so the guest knows what's coming
- B) Begin speaking while you pour — description concurrent with the first pour
- C) Pour all glasses first, then describe — so guests have the wine as you speak
- D) Let the guest smell the bottle before any verbal description

3. Priorat is a wine region located in:

- A) The Rioja DOC, near Logroño
- B) Castile-La Mancha, in central Spain
- C) Catalonia, in north-eastern Spain
- D) Andalusia, near Jerez

4. Sofia's three-second stillness before beginning her exam pour is:

- A) Visible nerves that the examiner notes as a negative
- B) An Elena technique: look before you pour — the stillness is about reading the room
- C) A mandatory Le Cordon Bleu exam requirement
- D) An improvised delay to compose herself

SERVICE SCENARIO

You're at an exam station. Brief: describe and pour a Rioja. You have the bottle, one glass, a host, and thirty seconds before your first pour.

Write out your full description — what you say, how you say it, when you pour. Then list three things you deliberately chose not to say, and why.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I can describe a wine in flavour, texture, and pairing terms without notes
- ☐ I speak concurrent with the pour — description and action arrive together
- ☐ I know the basic structural pairing logic: tannins cut fat, acidity cuts richness
- ☐ I maintain eye contact while pouring — I trust my hands without watching them
- ☐ I accept a 98% as information, not ego — and go back to find the 2%

CHAPTER 11

London Ikoyi

London, UK — Ikoyi at St James's Market

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Six weeks in, Luca has a storytelling breakthrough. Jeremy Chan's instruction: "Food without story is fuel — tell them where it swam, who harvested it." At table eight, Luca narrates the plantain's journey from Accra markets to grass-fed tallow fry. The guest says "I've never been to Accra." He says "You taste it now." He stays for dumplings with Kwame and Elena afterward. Two months ago he would have left at 23:45 exactly.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Jeremy Chan's instruction to Luca about service narration is:

- A) "Get the technical description right and everything else follows"
- B) "Food without story is fuel — tell them where it swam, who harvested it"
- C) "Precision must come before personality at all times"
- D) "Let the guest lead; your job is to respond"

2. The suya lamb shoulder's yaji spice rub originates in:

- A) Lagos
- B) Kano
- C) Abuja
- D) Accra

3. "Egusi" — used in the sauce at Ikoyi — is:

- A) A Nigerian fermented pepper and palm oil sauce
- B) A smoked dried fish used as a seasoning
- C) Ground melon seed, cooked into a rich, earthy sauce with depth and delayed sweetness
- D) A West African fresh herb similar to basil

4. When Luca tells the guest "You taste it now," he is demonstrating:

- A) The power of closing a sale with confidence
- B) How storytelling transfers a sense of place — the guest experiences Accra through the dish
- C) A sales technique recommended by Ikoyi management
- D) How to handle a guest unfamiliar with the cuisine

SERVICE SCENARIO

Choose a dish from your current menu — or invent one. Write your full tableside narration: the ingredient's origin, how it was grown or raised, what the technique does to it, and what the guest will experience.

Keep it under 45 seconds spoken aloud. Then annotate it: for each sentence, explain why it earns its place and what you cut.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I know the provenance of every dish on my current menu — farm, region, technique
- ☐ I can tell an ingredient's story in 30 seconds without it sounding like a pitch
- ☐ I read whether a guest wants the story before I start telling it
- ☐ I understand the difference between storytelling and performing
- ☐ I connect the story to what the guest is about to experience on the plate

CHAPTER 12

The Almost

London, UK — Honourable Artillery Company, Armoury Lane

CHAPTER SUMMARY

At a hospitality mixer, Sofia and Luca are steered toward each other by their respective colleagues. They meet, shake hands, begin a conversation. He notices her calluses match his. She thinks: "I've seen that half-smile before." He is composing the right question when the fire alarm goes off. They end up twenty meters apart across a rain-soaked lane, looking at each other for three seconds before a fire truck drives between them. He goes home and writes: "Not yet."

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. When Luca takes Sofia's hand for the first time, he notices:

- A) That it's cold and formally professional, as expected
- B) A softness that surprises him given her reputation
- C) That her calluses match his — tray work, bottle work, the specific friction of the job
- D) That she's watching him more than the conversation

2. Luca's final notebook entry for the chapter is:

- A) "Florence. Natural awareness. Variable."
- B) "HAC. Three seconds. Armoury Lane."
- C) "Precision and warmth. Not opposites."
- D) "Paris precision. Keep working."

3. Sofia recognises Luca across the rain-soaked lane because:

- A) Clara tells her just before the alarm goes off
- B) She recognises his running shoes from the Pont des Arts
- C) She knows it the way a chord resolves — not with argument, but with the whole body
- D) His name badge is still attached from the event

4. "Offering to the room rather than at the room" describes a service posture where:

- A) The server speaks loudly enough for all guests to hear
- B) The presentation feels like shared discovery rather than a sales pitch directed at one person
- C) The server allows guests to serve themselves from a central platter
- D) The maître d' makes all wine decisions on behalf of the table

SERVICE SCENARIO

Think about a service moment from your own work — or one described in the novel — where everything was technically correct, but something felt missing.

What was absent? What would "precision with soul" have looked like in that moment? Use at least one specific example from First Crossings to frame your answer.

SKILLS CHECKLIST

Tick what you own · Circle what you're working on · Leave blank what you haven't started

- ☐ I understand the difference between executing service and being genuinely present in it
- ☐ I can describe what "precision with soul" looks like in a real shift
- ☐ I can name one character moment from First Crossings I want to carry into my own work
- ☐ I know the one thing I want to practise most after reading this book
- ☐ I have written down something from this workbook worth keeping

ANSWER KEY

Knowledge Check Answers

With explanations.

Ch. 1 — THE CITY THAT STARTS WITHOUT YOU

1. Answer: B) A brief story, offered to the room — not at it

Elena offers the wine with a brief story rather than a recitation, inviting the couple in rather than lecturing them. The wife leans forward. That lean is the goal.

2. Answer: C) Clockwise from the right, host last

Pour clockwise from the right, saving the host for last. This lets the host confirm the wine is correct before their guests are served.

3. Answer: C) Snapped her elbow to her ribs, threw her hip weight left, and kept moving

The save was a body response executed in under a second without stopping. The technique had been practised until it became reflex, not decision.

4. Answer: C) The vitello (veal)

"Beautiful tonight with the vitello." The word "tonight" makes it feel like a discovery, not a rote fact.

Ch. 2 — PARIS PRECISION

1. Answer: C) Offer a bridge wine without framing it as compensation for a delay

A bridge wine makes the delay invisible. Luca doesn't say "I'm sorry, the kitchen is behind" — he says "allow me a bridge." The table never experiences a delay. They experience a bonus.

2. Answer: C) Morey-Saint-Denis

Clos de Tart is a grand cru monopole in Morey-Saint-Denis, Côte de Nuits. Luca describes it as "violet and earth, nothing heavy."

3. Answer: B) Horizontally, label angled toward the light so Laurent can confirm

Presenting the bottle horizontally with the label in the light invites the guest to confirm their choice. The final decision stays with them.

4. Answer: B) Two paces, close but not hovering

Two paces. Close enough to read the table, far enough not to crowd it.

Ch. 3 — THE NEAR MISS

1. Answer: C) An involuntary reflex she applies everywhere — trains, queues, café windows

"You couldn't un-learn it." Real service awareness becomes ambient — it stops being a professional tool and starts being how you experience the world.

2. Answer: B) "You learn or you don't"

A Amalfi-born woman who could read a stranger's mood from across a terrace — her entire teaching was this single sentence.

3. Answer: B) Making the description feel like shared discovery rather than a sales pitch

The distinction is the posture of the offer. "At the room" is a pitch — "to the room" is an invitation.

4. Answer: B) Anticipatory service

Anticipatory service is the hallmark of Michelin-level hospitality — the need is met before it becomes a request.

Ch. 4 — FLORENCE RHYTHM

1. Answer: C) Ask "When did you notice it cooling?" — then listen fully before responding

The question disarms the complaint. He was braced for an excuse. Instead he's given space to be heard.

2. Answer: B) A bitter alpine digestif with a grappa base

Amaro Nonino is a bitter herbal digestif with a grappa base, produced in Friuli.

3. Answer: B) Setting the glasses down as if this had always been part of the evening's plan

A comp announced as a comp is a transaction. A comp delivered as a gift is hospitality.

4. Answer: A) Tuscany

Brunello di Montalcino is a DOCG from the hills of Montalcino in Tuscany, made from Sangiovese Grosso.

Ch. 5 — PARIS DEEPENING

1. Answer: C) "Precision is the frame. Empathy fills it."

Precision creates the conditions for human connection. The technically correct service is the frame; the warmth fills it with meaning.

2. Answer: C) Placing warm rye bread silently, as though it had always been planned

No apology, no acknowledgment of delay. Just bread, warm, at the right moment. The table never experiences a wait — they experience a gift.

3. Answer: B) Tasting and listening for whether it "sings" — a subjective aliveness

"Feel it. Does it sing?" Verjus teaches sensory authority — trust your palate over the spec sheet.

4. Answer: B) Technical excellence and human connection reinforce each other

This is the book's central thesis. Precision without warmth is cold; warmth without precision is chaos. Each makes the other possible.

Ch. 6 — THE CITY THAT SHOUTS

1. Answer: B) 1914

Founded in 1914 on Carrer del Poeta Cabanyes, now run by the fourth generation.

2. Answer: C) Brings razor clams without being asked — and watches their faces shift

She reads the uncertainty as a request for guidance and acts before they have to ask. Anticipatory service in a standing-room bar.

3. Answer: B) Premium tinned seafood and preserved produce

Conservas are premium tinned and jarred seafood — razor clams, spider crab, sea urchin, cockles, anchovies. Serious product, not convenience food.

4. Answer: C) Disfrutar (three stars, Oriol Castro's team)

"You got the speed." Quim is pointing her from controlled chaos toward the precision end of the spectrum.

Ch. 7 — MILLIMETER WORK

1. Answer: B) After placing a transforming course, step back and let the moment happen at its own pace

The espuma tower melts. The consommé shifts colour. Walking back in with words breaks the spell.

2. Answer: B) Birch sap spheres, moss gelée in porcelain hollows, and a nitro-frozen espuma tower

Three courses that build as a narrative: birch sap (cold, effervescent), moss gelée (still, earthy), espuma tower (fifteen-second transformation into mushroom consommé).

3. Answer: C) Temperature change begins a fifteen-second timed transformation — the guest watches it happen

"Mushroom forest mist — melts in fifteen." The clock starts when it hits the table's warmth. Her job at the table is already done.

4. Answer: C) A two-handed correction — thumb driving the tray edge, free hand's pinky feathering under the espuma base

She'd never drilled this specific geometry, but the body knew it. Quimet gave her speed; Florence gave her the tray reflex. Disfrutar required both at once.

Ch. 8 — THE WIDOWER'S WINE

1. Answer: B) He's pieced together from fragments that Henriot's wife loved this wine

Luca pieces this together from fragments over three weeks — a passing mention, information from Raoul, careful observation. The gift works because it came from genuine attention, not data.

2. Answer: B) A white Burgundy from the Côte de Beaune

Chassagne-Montrachet is a premier and grand cru village appellation on the Côte de Beaune, producing some of Burgundy's finest Chardonnays.

3. Answer: B) Retreats two paces and doesn't look back for twelve minutes

"Henriot deserved those twelve minutes to sit with whatever the wine had opened in him." The work is done. Returning too soon would interrupt something private.

4. Answer: C) A guest's emotional state shapes what they actually need tonight — read it and respond

Not companionship, not prying — awareness. Knowing Henriot is lonely means Luca reads what he needs that evening: a specific bottle, then space.

Ch. 9 — LONDON BOROUGH MARKET

1. Answer: B) An off-dry Riesling, whose residual sweetness cools the heat

Residual sugar in an off-dry Riesling soothes capsaicin heat. Tannins in a red would amplify the burn.

2. Answer: C) Sea brine, a green melon mid-note, and a chalk mineral finish

Sofia writes: "sea brine, green melon, chalk finish." Luca reads the same notes upside-down. The quality of the writing is part of what makes him stop.

3. Answer: B) South African Chenin Blanc

South African Chenin Blanc — stone fruit to echo the caramelised plantain edge, enough acidity to cut the fermented shrimp butter.

4. Answer: B) Hibiscus and pineapple leaf, chilled, used as a palate-reset bridge

Hibiscus acidity and pineapple-leaf brightness served cold — the same logic as a wine bridge: interrupt the heat before it peaks, without stopping the meal's momentum.

Ch. 10 — BARCELONA FAREWELL

1. Answer: B) The wine's tannins cut the fat of the cured meat — a structural pairing

"The tannins cut the fat of the jamón" — tannin in the wine binds to fat protein in the jamón, cleansing the palate. This is why red wine and charcuterie work.

2. Answer: B) Begin speaking while you pour — description concurrent with the first pour

Description concurrent with pouring — the language and the wine arrive together as a single sensory event.

3. Answer: C) Catalonia, in north-eastern Spain

Priorat (or Priorato) is a DOCa in Catalonia known for intense mineral red wines from old Grenache and Carignan vines on llicorella (slate) soils.

4. Answer: B) An Elena technique: look before you pour — the stillness is about reading the room

"Look before you pour." Started as a floor-reading habit in Florence; at the exam it becomes its own small statement of readiness.

Ch. 11 — LONDON IKOYI

1. Answer: B) "Food without story is fuel — tell them where it swam, who harvested it"

Not decoration — information. The story of an ingredient is its reason for existing on the plate.

2. Answer: B) Kano

Kano, in northern Nigeria, is the heartland of suya culture and the yaji spice blend — grains of paradise, grains of Selim, alligator pepper.

3. Answer: C) Ground melon seed, cooked into a rich, earthy sauce with depth and delayed sweetness

Egusi seeds come from a variety of melon grown across West Africa. When ground and cooked, they produce a thick sauce with earthy, sweet, and savoury depth.

4. Answer: B) How storytelling transfers a sense of place — the guest experiences Accra through the dish

"I've never been to Accra." "You taste it now." The food becomes a vehicle for transport — precision delivered what Chan called "the thing itself."

Ch. 12 — THE ALMOST

1. Answer: C) That her calluses match his — tray work, bottle work, the specific friction of the job

"Callused in the places that matched his." The handshake is a form of recognition — two people who have done the same work, in the same way, for years.

2. Answer: B) "HAC. Three seconds. Armoury Lane."

"HAC. Three seconds. Armoury Lane." Below the entry from months ago that started as professional observation — now something else entirely.

3. Answer: C) She knows it the way a chord resolves — not with argument, but with the whole body

The recognition doesn't come from the face. She recognises the quality of presence — the precise hands, the way he holds his shoulders, the laugh she heard at La Boqueria.

4. Answer: B) The presentation feels like shared discovery rather than a sales pitch directed at one person

This phrase appears first in Chapter 1 and anchors the book's service philosophy. The difference between a pitch and an invitation is entirely in the posture of the person making it.

Keep going.

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